
The Overall Creative Head *Handbook.*

A working curriculum for the leader who now owns the performance of Logo, Packaging, R&D and Internal Content — built to be read aloud, one section at a time, with the Founder in the room.

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Forty-nine sections, eight parts. Work through them in order — each one is a conversation, not a memo.

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HOW TO USE THIS HANDBOOK

Read one section. Discuss the examples. Fill in the notes together. Agree on actions before moving to the next page.

SIX SECTIONS

The Role

What you're actually being asked to do — and, just as importantly, what you're being asked to stop doing.

-
- 01 Context of the Role
 - 02 From Performer to Multiplier
 - 03 Role Mission
 - 04 What This Role Is Not
 - 05 Authority & Reporting Structure
 - 06 The Agency You're Leading

01

PART ONE – THE ROLE

Context of the Role

You've been given authority over something bigger than a team. You've been given authority over how every team performs.

Brandstro now runs several creative functions that each need to work well on their own, and work well together: the **Logo / Brand Identity Team**, the **Packaging Team, R&D and Sketch**, and the **Internal Content Creation Team**. Each of these has, or will have, its own Team Leader running day-to-day work.

You are being placed above the individual Team Leaders — not as a bigger Team Leader yourself, but as the person responsible for the performance, discipline, development, coordination, productivity and growth of the whole creative ecosystem.

YOU ARE NOT

- The person who personally executes every design task.
- Expected to micromanage individual designers.
- Primarily responsible for client servicing.

YOU ARE

- Responsible for making Team Leaders better at leading.
- Responsible for making teams better at producing.
- Responsible for building the systems that make performance repeatable — not dependent on any one person's mood or memory.
- Responsible for catching problems before they become client-facing emergencies.

Why you, and why now

You led the Logo Team when it was underperforming, and you turned it around. That is the exact evidence the Founder is promoting on — not your personal design output, but proof that you can change how a group of people performs. The Packaging Team has real, current problems: missed deadlines, inconsistent quality, unclear ownership between managing and designing. Your job is **not** to become the new Packaging Team Leader and fix it by hand. Your job is to work with the Packaging Team Leader so the team fixes itself — and stays fixed after you've moved your attention elsewhere.

HOLD ONTO THIS

The Logo Team improved because you were close to it every day. The next test is whether Packaging, R&D and Content can improve without you being close to them every day.

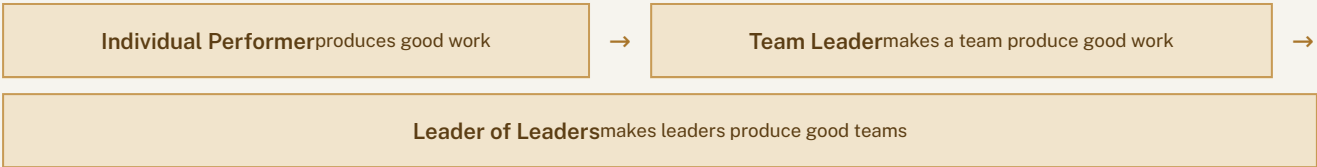
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PART ONE – THE ROLE

From Performer to Multiplier

Your job is no longer to be the best individual performer. Your job is to make the entire team perform better.

Every creative career moves through the same three stages, and each stage rewards a different kind of thinking. Confusing the stages is the single most common reason a good promotion goes badly.



LEVEL	MEASURED BY	MAIN RISK IF STUCK AT THE WRONG LEVEL
Individual Performer	Quality of your own logos, packs, sketches	You stay valuable, but the agency stays capped at what you can personally touch.
Team Leader	Whether your team hits quality and deadlines without you doing the work yourself	You become a bottleneck — the team can't move faster than you can review.
Leader of Leaders	Whether your Team Leaders are becoming stronger, independent decision-makers	You quietly become an over-qualified Packaging Team Leader instead of a Creative Head.

Notice what changes at each step: an Individual Performer is judged on output. A Team Leader is judged on their team's output. You will be judged on whether the *Team Leaders* — including the one running Packaging right now — are getting better at running their teams. That is a different skill from being a strong designer, and it is the one this handbook trains.

HOLD ONTO THIS

A strong individual contributor produces good work. A strong Team Leader makes their team produce good work. A strong Creative Head makes Team Leaders become stronger leaders.

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PART ONE — THE ROLE

Role Mission

One sentence the Founder should be able to hold you to, every month.

MISSION STATEMENT

I own the health and performance of the overall creative department — the strength of its Team Leaders, the productivity, quality and accountability of every team, and the systems that let it grow without breaking. Each Team Leader still owns their own team.

That single sentence expands into fourteen concrete ownership areas. Use this list as a checklist, not as decoration — if you can't point to evidence for a row, that's a gap to close this month.

OWNERSHIP AREA	WHAT "GOOD" LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE
Team performance	Every team hits agreed output and quality, most months, without heroics.
Team Leader development	Leaders can diagnose their own team's problems before you point them out.
Employee development	Every employee has a named next skill they're working on.
Productivity	Workload matches capacity; nobody is silently overloaded or idle.
Quality	First-presentation work is strong enough that revisions are the exception.
Accountability	When something slips, the reason is known — not guessed at.
Problem-solving	Recurring problems get systems, not repeated pep talks.
Process improvement	The workflow gets a little better every month, not just when something breaks.
Capacity planning	You can say, today, whether the team can take on ten more logo projects this week.
Work allocation	Work goes to the right person for the right reason, not whoever is least busy.
Team culture	People take ownership without being told, and admit mistakes without fear.
Performance tracking	You can show trends, not just this week's snapshot.
Conflict management	Disagreements get resolved, not avoided or escalated by default.
Leadership pipeline	You already know who could run a team next, before you need them to.

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PART ONE — THE ROLE

What You Are NOT Here to Do

Leadership is leverage. Every hour you spend doing a Team Leader's job is an hour you didn't spend making them capable of doing it without you.

This is the section people skip and then relearn the hard way three months in, usually around the same time they realise they're busier than ever and nothing has actually improved.

DO NOT

- Micromanage every designer's file, revision, or sketch.
- Take over a Team Leader's responsibilities because it's faster than coaching them through it.
- Become the default answer to every small problem — that trains people to stop solving things themselves.
- Bypass Team Leaders unless the situation genuinely requires it.
- Create dependency on yourself, personally, for decisions your leaders should own.
- Take over client relationships that belong to the Client Relationship Manager or the relevant Team Leader.
- Publicly undermine a Team Leader, even when they're wrong.
- Jump to a solution before you understand the actual cause.
- Measure people only by hours logged or how busy they look.
- Chase only urgent fires while long-term development quietly never happens.

None of this means disappearing. It means being present in a way that builds capability instead of replacing it. The test for almost every decision in this role is simple:

THE TEST

Does this build a system or a leader that will still work when I'm not in the room — or does it just get today's problem out of my inbox?

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PART ONE – THE ROLE

Authority & Reporting Structure

Everyone should be able to answer "who decides this?" without asking you.

- Founder

Business direction, strategic pricing and packages, major escalations, culture expectations, final call on hiring.
- Creative Head

Department-wide performance, Team Leader development, cross-team coordination, productivity, quality standards, problem-solving, capacity planning, process improvement.
- Team Leaders

Daily team management, task allocation, individual performance, quality checking within the team, team-level deadlines, coaching, escalating what's genuinely beyond them.
- Team Members

Executing assigned work, meeting quality and deadline standards, communicating blockers early, improving skills, following process.

Right now, Team Leaders at Brandstro split their time informally between managing their team and doing their own design work, with no fixed division. That ambiguity is exactly what this structure exists to reduce — not by banning Team Leaders from designing, but by making clear that when the two conflict, the team's performance is the job, and their own output is secondary.

WHERE RESPONSIBILITY STARTS AND ENDS

SITUATION	WHO OWNS IT FIRST
A designer's revision count is climbing on one project	Team Leader
The same revision pattern is happening across two teams	Creative Head
A client threatens to leave over a missed deadline	Founder, informed immediately by Creative Head
A Team Leader consistently misses their own team's deadlines	Creative Head coaches; escalates to Founder only if it doesn't improve

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PART ONE – THE ROLE

The Agency You're Leading

Brandstro is not a generic design studio. It's a branding agency — and one function inside it doesn't serve clients at all.

Everything in this handbook applies across Brandstro, but two environments inside the agency run on different logic, and treating them the same is a mistake worth naming early.

CLIENT-FACING PRODUCTION

- Logo / Brand Identity Team
- Packaging Team
- R&D / Sketch Team

Judged by: client approval, revision count, on-time delivery, technical quality.

INTERNAL AGENCY CONTENT

- Content Creation Team
- Agency social media, reels, portfolio, case studies, campaigns

Judged by: consistency of output, how well it sells Brandstro itself, not client sign-off.

The Content Team's job is to market **Brandstro** — not to serve an external client. Treat it as an internal business-growth function with its own calendar and its own creative direction, not as a fifth client-service team competing for the same kind of attention as Packaging.

THE TEAMS YOU'RE COORDINATING

TEAM	OWNS
Logo / Brand Identity	Logo concepts, identity systems, typography, colour systems, brand guidelines, applications.
Packaging	Packaging concepts, label design, structural thinking, print-readiness, mockups.
R&D / Sketch	Visual research, concept exploration, sketching, references — in support of Logo and Packaging.
Internal Content	Brandstro's own social presence, portfolio storytelling, case studies, campaigns.

CENTRAL MESSAGE OF THIS HANDBOOK

You are being promoted because you have already shown you can make other people better at doing the work — not because you're good at doing the work yourself. Turning the Logo Team around was the evidence. Building a system where Logo, Packaging, R&D and Content can each keep improving on their own is the job now.

Discussion Pages — End of Part One

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

TEN SECTIONS

Leading the Leaders

The core skill of the role: coaching, performance, conflict, delegation, feedback and culture — applied to Team Leaders first, and through them, to everyone else.

- 07 You Are Now a Leader of Leaders
- 08 Performance Management Framework
- 09 Handling Underperforming Employees
- 10 Problem-Solving Framework
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- 13 Micromanagement vs Leadership
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- 15 How to Give Feedback
- 16 Team Culture

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PART TWO — LEADING THE LEADERS

You Are Now a Leader of Leaders

The single highest-leverage use of your time is making each Team Leader better at their job.

Every hour spent coaching a Team Leader well multiplies across everyone on their team, every week, indefinitely. That is a better return than almost anything else you could do with the hour — including doing the design work yourself.

WHAT "COACHING A TEAM LEADER" ACTUALLY MEANS

- **Review, don't rescue.** Look at their team's numbers with them; let them propose the fix first.
- **Set expectations explicitly.** Don't assume a Team Leader knows what "good" looks like unless you've said it out loud.
- **Give feedback on their leadership, not just their team's output.** "Your team missed the deadline" is a team problem. "You didn't flag the risk three days earlier when you could see it coming" is a leadership problem — and it's the one to coach.
- **Challenge weak decisions before they become habits.** If a Team Leader keeps absorbing overflow work personally instead of reallocating it, that's a pattern to interrupt early.
- **Teach the skills underneath the job:** delegation, planning, difficult conversations, performance management.

THE WEEKLY TEAM LEADER REVIEW — WHAT TO ASK EVERY LEADER, EVERY WEEK

AREA	QUESTION TO ASK
Output	What did your team finish this week, and what's still open?
Quality	What needed rework, and why?
Deadlines	What's at risk in the next seven days?
Client blockers	What's waiting on a client response or approval?
Team discipline & morale	Anything you're worried about with a specific person?
Bottlenecks	Where did work sit idle, and why?
Resourcing	Do you have enough people for what's coming next week?
Improvement action	What's one thing you'll do differently next week?

HOLD ONTO THIS

You are not there to answer for their team. You are there so they get better at answering for it themselves.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Performance Management Framework

You can't improve what you don't measure — but KPIs exist to improve people, not to intimidate them.

DIMENSION	THE REAL QUESTION
Output	How much work is actually being completed?
Quality	How good is the work, honestly?
Timeliness	Are deadlines being met?
Consistency	Is this stable, or dependent on one person's mood that week?
Efficiency	How much time and back-and-forth does it take to get there?
Improvement	Are people visibly getting better over time?
Accountability	Do people own their part, or explain it away?
Collaboration	Does this team make other teams' jobs easier or harder?
Problem-solving	Do people solve things themselves, or escalate everything?

PRACTICAL SCORECARD KPIS FOR A BRANDSTRO CREATIVE TEAM

Tasks assigned vs completed	On-time completion %	Revision rounds per project	Rework hours
Escalations	Client-facing errors		

These are the same signals already visible in how Brandstro runs today — R&D output, sketch turnaround, one logo per designer per day, revision rounds per client — just tracked deliberately instead of held in memory. Use a scorecard so a "bad month" is a fact you can point to, not a feeling either of you has to defend.

CAREFUL

KPIs used to catch people out train people to hide problems. KPIs used to spot where coaching is needed train people to raise their hand early. Same numbers, opposite culture, depending on how you use them.

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PART TWO — LEADING THE LEADERS

Handling Underperforming Employees

"This person is bad" is not a diagnosis. "This person's current performance is below the required standard, for this reason" is.

- 1 **Identify** — what exactly is underperforming? Name the specific output, not a general impression.
- 2 **Measure** — use the scorecard, not memory or a single bad week.
- 3 **Diagnose** — find the actual cause (see below).
- 4 **Coach** — a direct conversation, grounded in evidence, not accusation.
- 5 **Set an improvement plan** — specific, achievable, written down.
- 6 **Give a timeline** — a real date, not "soon."
- 7 **Review progress** — on the date you set, not whenever it comes up.
- 8 **Escalate if necessary** — to the Founder, with the full record, not just a complaint.

POSSIBLE CAUSES — DON'T GUESS, CHECK

- Skill gap
- Lack of clarity on the brief or standard
- Lack of training
- Wrong role for their strengths
- Workload — too much, or too little
- Poor management above them
- Personal issues outside work
- A process problem, not a people problem

A designer missing quality on packaging mockups might be undertrained on print-ready file setup, not careless. A Team Leader who keeps missing reviews might be buried doing design work they should have delegated. Diagnose before you coach — the coaching conversation is completely different depending on the cause.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Problem-Solving Framework

Don't solve symptoms. Solve causes.

When a project runs late, the easy response is "work faster." The useful response is to find out why it was ever going to be late in the first place — because "work faster" fixes nothing the next time the same thing happens.

THE 5 WHYS, APPLIED TO A REAL BRANDSTRO PATTERN

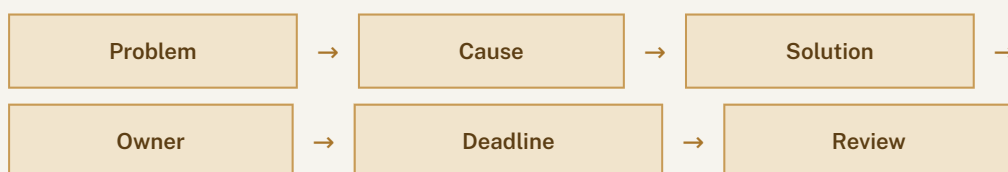
Why was the packaging project three days late? → The designer was waiting on R&D direction.

Why was R&D late? → R&D was covering two projects that day and this one wasn't flagged urgent.

Why wasn't it flagged? → There's no shared view of which projects are close to deadline.

Why isn't there one? → Nobody owns a simple, visible tracker across teams.

Root cause: a coordination gap, not a slow designer.



NINE QUESTIONS FOR ANY RECURRING OFFICE PROBLEM

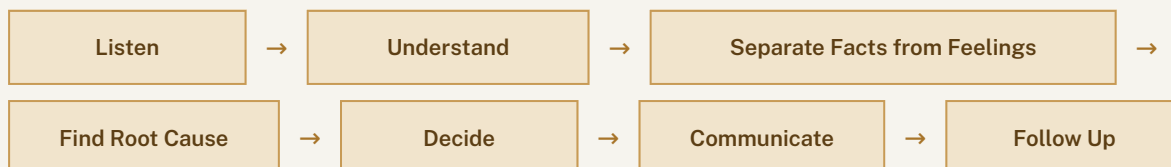
1. What happened, exactly?
2. Why did it happen?
3. Is this an individual problem or a system problem?
4. Has this happened before?
5. Who owns the problem?
6. What immediate action is required?
7. What prevents it from happening again?
8. How will we measure improvement?
9. When will we review it?

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Handling Team Conflict

Every kind of conflict in a creative team follows the same resolution path — only the parties change.



CONFLICT TYPES YOU'LL SEE

- Designer vs Designer
- Designer vs Team Leader
- Team Leader vs Team Leader
- Team Leader vs you
- Ego clashes over creative direction
- Blame culture after a missed deadline
- Unequal workload complaints
- Quality or deadline disagreements

SAMPLE CONVERSATION OPENER

"I want to understand both sides before anyone decides anything. [Person A], tell me what happened from where you sat. [Person B], same for you. I'm not looking for who's right yet — just what actually happened."

Two Team Leaders blaming each other for a missed handoff between R&D and Packaging is common enough to plan for. Resist picking a side in the room. Get both accounts, find the actual handoff gap, fix the process, and only then address any individual behaviour that needs correcting — separately, not in front of each other.

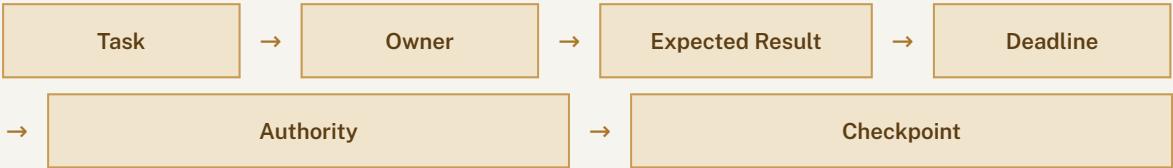
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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Delegation

If you do everything yourself, you have created a dependency, not a team.

This applies to you and it applies to every Team Leader below you. Right now, Team Leaders split time between managing their team and doing their own design work with no fixed line between the two. Left alone, that always drifts toward more designing and less managing — because designing has a visible, finishable output and managing often doesn't. Teach every Team Leader to notice that drift in themselves.



WHAT TO DELEGATE, AND HOW MUCH AUTHORITY TO GIVE

DELEGATE	KEEP
Day-to-day task allocation within a team	Department-wide priority calls
First-pass quality review	Coaching Team Leaders on how they review
Client-ready file checks	Cross-team resourcing decisions
Routine client updates on progress	Anything that changes scope, pricing or timeline

Monitoring without micromanaging means checking outcomes at the checkpoint you agreed — not walking past someone's screen every hour. If a Team Leader needs that kind of oversight to perform, that's a coaching conversation, not a reason to take the task back.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Micromanagement vs Leadership

Leadership doesn't mean disappearing. It means creating visibility without creating suffocation.

MICROMANAGER	LEADER
• Reviews every file before it moves an inch • Reacts to mistakes with blame • Makes every decision themselves • Trusts no one by default • Gives feedback only when something's wrong • Delegates tasks, never authority • Develops dependency on themselves • Solves every problem personally	• Reviews at agreed checkpoints • Reacts to mistakes with a fix and a lesson • Lets the right person decide at the right level • Trusts by default, verifies with evidence • Gives feedback as a habit, not a punishment • Delegates the outcome, not just the task • Builds a team that works without them • Builds people who solve problems themselves

HOLD ONTO THIS

Being easy to talk to is not the same as being easy to walk over. Being firm is not the same as being arrogant. You can hold both.

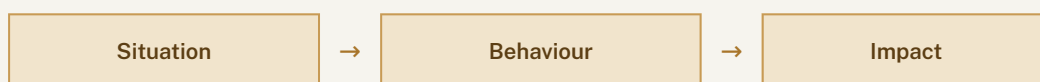
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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Communication

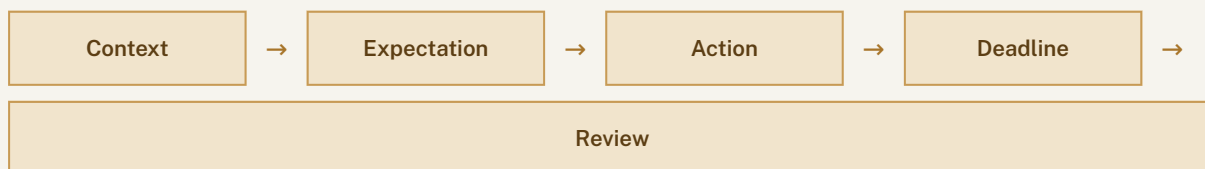
Two frameworks will carry almost every conversation you need to have in this role.

SBI – FOR FEEDBACK



"In yesterday's client review (situation), the mockup was sent without the die-line checked (behaviour), which meant the client caught a print error we should have caught first (impact)."

CLEAR – FOR INSTRUCTIONS AND DELEGATION



WHERE TONE CHANGES

AUDIENCE	WHAT CHANGES
Team Leaders	Peer-level directness; discuss trade-offs, not just instructions.
Junior designers	More context, more explanation of "why," patience with questions.
Founder	Lead with the headline and the recommendation, not the full story first.

Saying "no" is part of this job — to a Team Leader who wants to skip a review step, to a request that would bypass a process for convenience. Say it plainly, with the reason attached, and offer what you can say "yes" to instead.

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

How to Give Feedback

*Don't attack the person. Correct the behaviour.***ATTACKS THE PERSON**

- "You are careless."
- "You never think things through."
- "This is exactly like last time."

CORRECTS THE BEHAVIOUR

- "This task had three avoidable errors, which cost us extra revision time."
- "Let's look at what led to that, and how we prevent it next time."
- "What would help you catch this before it goes out?"

FIVE KINDS OF FEEDBACK YOU'LL GIVE IN THIS ROLE

TYPE	WHEN
Positive	Reinforce specifically — name what worked, not just "good job."
Corrective	Address a specific, recent, observable behaviour.
Performance	Tied to the scorecard, at a scheduled review.
Leadership	To a Team Leader, about how they led — not what their team produced.
Difficult	Serious, repeated, or values-based issues — planned, private, direct.

RULE OF THUMB*Praise publicly. Correct privately.*

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PART TWO – LEADING THE LEADERS

Team Culture

Friendly workplace does not mean casual accountability.

Brandstro is three months old. It doesn't have three years of accumulated habits yet — which means the culture forming right now is unusually easy to shape, and unusually easy to shape badly by accident. What you reward and what you let slide in these next few months becomes "how we do things here" for a long time.

BUILD TOWARD

- Accountability and ownership
- Respect across teams
- Discipline without fear
- Learning and honest mistakes
- Quality as a habit, not an inspection
- Transparency about problems
- Professionalism under deadline pressure
- Continuous, unglamorous improvement

REWARD

Raising a problem early. Admitting a mistake before it's found. Helping another team hit its deadline. Asking a clarifying question instead of guessing.

DON'T TOLERATE

Hiding a slipping deadline until it's a crisis. Blaming another team without checking facts. Repeating the same avoidable error without adjusting.

Psychological safety and low accountability are not the same thing. A team where people feel safe naming a problem — and are still expected to fix it — is the target. A team where nothing is anyone's fault is not psychological safety; it's an absence of standards.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Two

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

SIX SECTIONS

Running the Department

Workload, coordination, client boundaries, quality, training and the pipeline of future leaders — the operational half of the job.

-
- 17 Productivity & Workload Management
 - 18 Cross-Team Coordination
 - 19 Client Involvement
 - 20 Quality Control
 - 21 Training & Development
 - 22 Leadership Pipeline

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Productivity & Workload Management

You cannot manage capacity you haven't measured.

Brandstro's throughput is already fairly well understood at the individual level: R&D can direct roughly two projects a day, the Sketch Artist about one sketch a day, a Logo designer about one logo a day, and standalone label or packaging work runs one to two days plus a few more for confirmation rounds. That's real capacity data — the gap is turning it into a plan before the month gets busy, not after.

This month is the clearest example available: thirty new clients came in, but only six to eight projects have been completed, with the team fully loaded and no prior structure to manage the surge. That's not a motivation problem. It's a capacity-planning problem, and it will keep repeating until it's treated as one.

TOOLS TO INTRODUCE

TOOL	WHAT IT ANSWERS
Capacity Planning	Given today's team, how many projects can realistically start this week?
Workload Dashboard	Who is overloaded, who has room, right now?
Priority Matrix	Urgent-and-important vs important-but-not-urgent — what actually goes first?
Daily Task Review	Is today's plan still realistic by lunchtime?
Weekly Capacity Review	Are we about to overcommit next week?

HOLD ONTO THIS

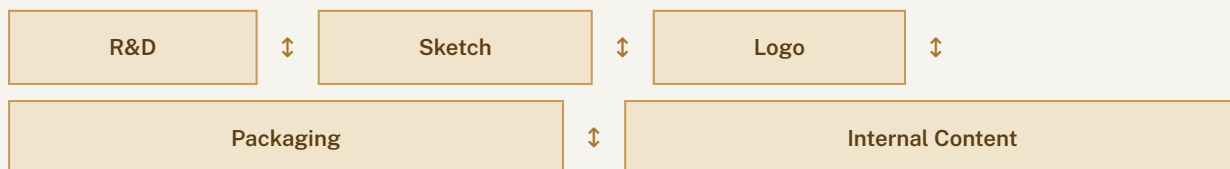
Thirty clients onboarded against six to eight completed isn't a sign the team needs to work harder. It's a sign intake needs to be paced to what the team can actually absorb.

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Cross-Team Coordination

Most delays don't happen inside a team. They happen in the handoff between teams.



Today, R&D sometimes briefs the Sketch Artist, sometimes sends ideas straight to Logo, and sometimes a Logo team member originates the concept themselves. All three paths can work — but only if everyone knows, for a given project, which path is happening. Ambiguity about the handoff is where "I thought R&D was still working on it" delays come from.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR AT EVERY HANDOFF

- Is it clear who has the project right now, at all times?
- Are shared resources (a sketch, a reference, a brief) available to the next team without asking around?
- Is there a visible signal when something is close to deadline, so it doesn't compete evenly with everything else?
- Is work ever being duplicated because two people didn't know someone else already started it?

SIMPLE FIX WORTH TESTING

A single shared status view — even a basic sheet — showing project, current owner, and days-to-deadline. Most cross-team delays disappear once "who has this right now" stops being a question anyone has to ask out loud.

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Client Involvement

You are not the Client Relationship Manager. Don't quietly become one.

You may attend important client meetings, join creative discussions, support a difficult project, or represent creative leadership when it genuinely calls for it. What you should avoid is absorbing day-to-day client communication that belongs to the CRM or the relevant Team Leader — every time you take that on personally, you make the department more dependent on you, not less.

SITUATION	YOUR ROLE
Routine revision request	Team Leader handles it directly
Client unhappy after multiple revision rounds	You join to understand the creative disagreement, alongside the CRM
Major client escalation or threat to leave	You and the Founder together
Understanding what clients actually want, in general	You track patterns across projects to inform brief quality and training

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Quality Control

Quality should be built into the process, not inspected only at the end.

Catching a weak logo concept at final client presentation is expensive — in time, in the client's confidence, and in the revision rounds that follow. Catching the same weakness at the R&D or sketch stage costs almost nothing. The earlier the checkpoint, the cheaper the fix.

STANDARDS WORTH WRITING DOWN ONCE, FOR EVERY TEAM

- Design standards and brand consistency
- Technical accuracy (print-ready, die-lines, colour modes)
- File organisation and naming conventions
- Presentation standards for client decks
- Revision control — which version is current
- Who gives final approval before a client sees it

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Training & Development

Ask, for every person: what's the one skill that would move them forward fastest?

- 1 Current skill — where are they today, honestly?
- 2 Required skill — what does the next level of their role actually need?
- 3 Gap — name the specific distance between the two.
- 4 Training — how will they close it?
- 5 Practice — where do they apply it on real work?
- 6 Review — did it actually close?

Ask this continuously: who needs training, what skills are missing on each team, who's ready for more responsibility, who could mentor someone junior. This doesn't need a formal HR process to start — it needs you noticing and writing it down.

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PART THREE – RUNNING THE DEPARTMENT

Leadership Pipeline

Brandstro should never depend on one or two leaders forever — including you.



Look for the signals continuously, not once a year: who solves problems without being asked, who other people naturally go to for help, who stays reliable under deadline pressure, who's already informally mentoring a junior teammate. Your own path — Logo designer to Logo Team Leader to Overall Creative Head — is the proof this pipeline works. It should not be the only example of it three years from now.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Three

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

EIGHT SECTIONS

Leadership Inside a Branding Agency

This is not generic creative leadership. This is how leadership works specifically inside a business that sells brand strategy, identity and packaging — where the vocabulary is concepts, revisions and client presentations.

-
- 23 Evaluating Creative Quality
 - 24 Creative Process Management
 - 25 Revision Management
 - 26 Creative vs Commercial Thinking
 - 27 Brief Quality
 - 28 Creative Review System
 - 29 Managing the Internal Content Team
 - 30 Branding-Agency Performance Dashboard

23

PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Evaluating Creative Quality

"Looks good" is not an evaluation. It's the absence of one.

Every review you give a Team Leader or a designer should be able to answer three questions: why is it good, what problem does it solve, and what could be stronger. That habit, repeated in every review, is what actually trains a team's creative judgement — far more than any single correction does.

DIMENSION	WHAT TO ACTUALLY ASK
Concept strength	Is there a real idea here, or just decoration?
Strategic relevance	Does it fit the brand's actual positioning, or just look nice in isolation?
Distinctiveness	Would this stand out next to five competitors' logos?
Simplicity & memorability	Could someone describe it after seeing it once?
Scalability	Does it hold up as a favicon and as a shopfront sign?
Typography & colour	Are these choices deliberate, or default?
Application	Does it work across packaging, stationery, a t-shirt?
Technical execution	Is the file actually production-ready?

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PART FOUR — LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Creative Process Management

Know the workflow well enough to spot exactly where a project is stuck.

- 1 Brief — client pays 50%, discovery call gathers direction.
- 2 R&D — concept research and direction (~2 projects/day capacity).
- 3 Sketch — minimal notebook sketch from the Sketch Artist (~1/day), sometimes skipped.
- 4 Design Development — Logo or Packaging team builds the concept out (~1 logo/day).
- 5 Team Leader Review — internal quality pass before it goes further.
- 6 Client Presentation — mockup delivered (typically ~5-page for logo).
- 7 Feedback & Revision — looped back into design, no formal sign-off step exists yet.
- 8 Final Delivery — remaining 50% collected before files are handed over.

The one gap worth naming directly: there's currently no formal client sign-off step between presentation and "done." That's exactly the kind of ambiguity that turns one more small tweak into an unplanned fourth revision round. Closing that gap is a process fix, not a talent fix.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Revision Management

The goal is not "reduce revisions." The goal is stronger thinking before the work ever reaches the client.

Brandstro's current pattern is actually informative: some clients approve the first draft outright, some ("fine" clients) need around two corrections, a few need three or more rounds, and very few need five or more. That spread is a real signal — first-presentation quality is already strong for a meaningful share of projects, and weak somewhere specific for the rest. The job is finding out where, not assuming revisions are evenly distributed bad luck.

FOUR THINGS TO TRACK

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Revision Rate	How many rounds, on average, per project type
First-Presentation Quality	What share of projects are approved on the first draft
Revision Root Cause	Was it a genuine design miss, or subjective client preference?
Client Feedback Pattern	Do the same kinds of notes keep recurring across different clients?

DISTINGUISH THESE TWO, EVERY TIME

Genuine design problem: the brief's objective wasn't actually met. Fix the thinking. **Subjective preference:** the work is solid but not to this client's personal taste. Fix the brief-gathering, not the design team.

Since the ₹15,000 branding package currently sells with informally unlimited revisions for a few clients, this isn't only a quality question — it's a margin question. A project stuck at five rounds is eating designer time that was priced for two. Revision discipline protects the team's time as much as it protects quality.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Creative vs Commercial Thinking

A beautiful design that doesn't solve the client's problem hasn't succeeded.

Neither has a safe design with no creative distinction.

Teach every Team Leader to hold both questions at once, on every project: is this creatively strong, and does it actually do the commercial job the client hired us for? A logo that wins internal admiration but confuses the target customer has failed just as surely as one that's technically safe but forgettable.

ASK BOTH

"Would I be proud to put this in the portfolio?" *and* "Would this actually help this specific client's business?" If the answer to either is no, it isn't finished yet.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Brief Quality

Garbage brief → confused thinking → weak creative output → excessive revisions.

Weak output often doesn't start with the designer. It starts three steps earlier, at the discovery call, when a question that mattered didn't get asked.

THE BRIEFING CHECKLIST

- What is the brand, in one sentence?
- Who is the target audience?
- What is the positioning?
- What is the business objective?
- What should the brand communicate — and avoid?
- Who are the competitors?
- What are the exact deliverables and deadline?
- What does the client expect to see first?
- Any reference direction or strategic constraint?

Use [CLIENT INPUT REQUIRED] style flags anywhere a brief is missing something instead of letting R&D quietly assume an answer — an assumed answer that turns out wrong is exactly what produces a revision round that didn't need to happen.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Creative Review System

Before work moves forward, someone should deliberately check seven things — not just glance and approve.

CHECK	QUESTION
Strategy	Does the concept actually make sense for this brand?
Concept	Is there a strong idea underneath the execution?
Design	Is the execution itself strong?
Brand Fit	Does it genuinely belong to this brand, or could it belong to anyone?
Distinctiveness	Does it stand apart from competitors?
Application	Will it hold up in real-world use — packaging, signage, small sizes?
Technical Quality	Is the file actually production-ready?

This is the checkpoint that should sit before client presentation, every time — not as an extra delay, but as the reason the client sees fewer weak first drafts.

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PART FOUR – LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Managing the Internal Content Creation Team

This team sells Brandstro. It doesn't serve a client — treat it that way.

The Content Team owns Brandstro's own Instagram behind-the-scenes presence, portfolio storytelling, case studies, and campaigns — including projects like the agency's own reels account and lead-generation experiments. Its output markets the agency itself, so judge it by a different yardstick than client-facing production: consistency and how well it builds the Brandstro brand, not client sign-off.

YOU OWN DIRECTION AND QUALITY. THE CONTENT TEAM LEADER OWNS DAILY EXECUTION.

YOU ENSURE

- A content calendar exists and is followed
- Creative direction stays consistent with the agency's brand
- Case studies actually get made from finished client work
- Quality control before anything publishes

THEY OWN

- Shoot planning and editing workflow
- Day-to-day posting and scheduling
- The approval process before publish

Don't become this team's daily task manager unless something is genuinely broken. The same leverage principle from Part One applies here as much as it does to Logo or Packaging.

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PART FOUR — LEADERSHIP INSIDE A BRANDING AGENCY

Branding-Agency Performance Dashboard

A dashboard built for what Brandstro actually sells — not a generic agency template.

AREA	TRACK
Production	Projects received, completed, in progress, pending, delayed
Logo / Identity	Concepts completed, first-presentation quality, revision rounds, turnaround time
Packaging	Concepts completed, revision rounds, turnaround time, technical errors caught
R&D	Concepts/research delivered, support requests, turnaround time
Internal Content	Content planned vs produced vs published, pending items
People	Attendance, productivity, training progress, leadership development

This doesn't need new software to start. It needs the numbers Brandstro already generates — logo-only at ₹6,000, the ₹15,000 branding package, the current team of one R&D, one Sketch Artist, a four-person Logo team, and a Packaging team of a ₹12,000 Team Leader, a ₹12,000 senior member and two ₹10,000 members — tracked on a simple weekly sheet instead of held in memory.

HOLD ONTO THIS

You don't need a perfect dashboard on day one. You need one number per team, tracked every week, that you actually look at.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Four

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

ELEVEN SECTIONS

Operating Discipline

The daily habits, decisions and character that make everything in Parts Two through Four actually happen, week after week.

-
- 31 Daily / Weekly / Monthly Responsibilities
 - 32 Meeting Structures
 - 33 Decision-Making
 - 34 Escalation Management
 - 35 Accountability
 - 36 Emotional Intelligence
 - 37 Leadership Character
 - 38 Trust & Authority
 - 39 Handling Mistakes
 - 40 Building Systems
 - 41 Continuous Improvement & Growth Mindset

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Daily / Weekly / Monthly Responsibilities

A role this broad only stays manageable with a fixed rhythm.

DAILY

- Check overall workload and critical deadlines across all four teams
- Check for bottlenecks and yesterday's carry-overs
- Confirm Team Leader priorities for the day
- Handle anything genuinely urgent; resist handling everything else

WEEKLY

- Run the structured Team Leader Review (Section 07)
- Review pending work, quality trends, and training progress
- Set next week's priorities across teams

MONTHLY

- Department-level performance review — team-wise and overall
- Review quality and productivity trends, not just the latest snapshot
- Review the Leader's Scorecard with the Founder (Section 45)
- Set next month's priorities and flag resourcing needs early

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Meeting Structures

Every recurring meeting should earn its place on the calendar.

MEETING	LENGTH	PURPOSE
Daily leadership check-in	10–15 min	Surface today's risks before they grow
Weekly Team Leader Meeting	30–45 min	The structured review from Section 07
Monthly Department Review	60 min	Trends, scorecard, next month's priorities
One-to-One Employee Review	15–20 min	Individual development, not just output
Performance Improvement Meeting	As needed	Section 09's framework, in person
Problem-Solving Meeting	As needed	Section 10's framework, with the right people in the room
Post-Project Review	15 min	What worked, what didn't, on a completed project

For each: know the purpose, who needs to be there, the questions you'll ask, and what action items leave the room with an owner and a date. A meeting without an action item was a conversation, not a decision.

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Decision-Making

Decide → Delegate → Monitor → Review.

DECIDE INDEPENDENTLY WHEN	CONSULT TEAM LEADERS WHEN	CONSULT OR ESCALATE TO FOUNDER WHEN
It's within a single team's normal operation	It affects how a team works day-to-day	It changes pricing, scope, or a client relationship
It's reversible if wrong	The Team Leader has context you don't	It's a hiring, firing, or major spend decision
It's within your established authority	It sets a precedent across teams	It's a serious, repeated people problem

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Escalation Management

Don't escalate every small problem upward. Never hide a serious one to make performance look good.

LEVEL	WHO HANDLES IT	EXAMPLE
Level 1 — Team-level	Team Leader	A designer needs a second revision pass
Level 2 — Cross-team or repeated	Creative Head	The same handoff keeps breaking between R&D and Packaging
Level 3 — Major business, people, or client issue	Founder / Management	A client threatens to leave; a serious conduct issue

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Accountability

Responsibility without accountability creates excuses.

WHAT?	WHO?	WHEN?	EXPECTED STANDARD?	CURRENT STATUS?	NEXT ACTION?

Learn to hear the difference between an explanation, an excuse, and a root cause. "I was waiting on R&D" can be any of the three depending on whether it's followed by "...and I should have flagged it two days earlier" or by nothing at all.

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Emotional Intelligence

A leader cannot react emotionally to every problem — the team learns your reactions faster than your words.

DON'T

- Shout or raise your voice
- Insult or embarrass someone publicly
- Decide anything while angry
- Play favourites, or punish based on assumptions

Be calm, firm and fair — especially when a mistake is genuinely costly. The calmer your response to a real problem, the more people will bring you real problems early.

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Leadership Character

The standard you set becomes the standard they follow.

People copy behaviour far more than they follow instructions. If you're punctual, disciplined, and honest about your own mistakes, that becomes normal on every team you touch — without you ever writing a rule about it.

- Punctuality
- Discipline
- Professional communication
- Ownership
- Work ethic
- Honesty, even when inconvenient
- Confidentiality
- Consistency — the same standard on a good day and a bad one

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Trust & Authority

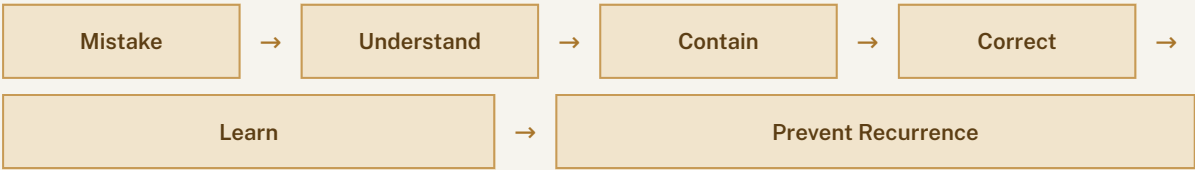
Hold both sides of each pair below – not one at the expense of the other.

BE	BUT NOT
Approachable	Easy to manipulate
Friendly	Favouritism-driven
Understanding	Weak on standards
Firm	Arrogant

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Handling Mistakes



Not every mistake deserves the same response. Know the difference before you react.

TYPE	RIGHT RESPONSE
Honest mistake	Fix it, no drama, note it for pattern-spotting
Repeated negligence	A direct, documented conversation
Lack of skill	Training, not discipline
Lack of attention	Understand the cause — workload, distraction, unclear priority
Intentional misconduct	Escalate to the Founder

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Building Systems

A recurring problem needs a system. It doesn't need another reminder to "work faster."

If deadlines are repeatedly missed, don't start with "try harder." Investigate: was it planning, capacity, unclear task allocation, a vague brief, a slow approval, a skill gap, or a review bottleneck? Then build the system that removes that specific cause — a checklist, a dashboard, an approval step, a training module, an escalation rule.

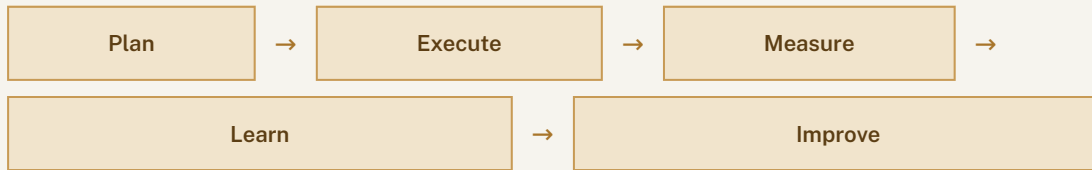
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Part Five – Operating Discipline

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PART FIVE – OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Continuous Improvement & Growth Mindset



Ask every month: what worked, what failed, what repeated, what wasted time, what created unnecessary revisions, what could be simplified, what should stop, start, or continue?

THE GROWTH-MINDSET QUESTION

If the team doubled in size tomorrow, would today's system survive? If not, that's the thing to fix now — while it's still cheap to fix.

Discussion Pages — End of Part Five

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

ONE SECTION

The First 90 Days

A practical runway for the transition — understand, then improve, then scale.

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PART SIX – THE FIRST 90 DAYS

The 30 / 60 / 90-Day Plan

Don't try to fix everything in week one. Understand first, improve second, scale third.

DAYS 1-30 – UNDERSTAND

- Understand all four teams and how work actually flows between them today
- Sit with each Team Leader; understand their real strengths and real gaps
- Map current problems — starting with Packaging, but across every team
- Establish baseline KPIs so "improvement" can be measured, not just felt

DAYS 31-60 – IMPROVE

- Fix the highest-priority problems identified in month one
- Begin structured coaching with each Team Leader
- Introduce basic reporting — the weekly review, the shared status view
- Start closing the biggest recurring gaps (see: the missing client sign-off step, Section 24)

DAYS 61-90 – SCALE

- Standardise what worked in month two across all teams
- Build the first version of the leadership pipeline (Section 22)
- Establish a sustainable operating rhythm — the daily/weekly/monthly cadence in Section 31
- Report back to the Founder on what changed, with numbers

HOLD ONTO THIS

Ninety days from now, the honest question isn't "did I personally fix Packaging?" It's "can Packaging now fix itself, faster than it could ninety days ago?"

THREE SECTIONS

Practice

Sixteen situations you will actually run into at Brandstro, plus the questions worth asking yourself on repeat.

43 Real Office Scenarios

44 Leadership Self-Reflection Questions

45 The Leader's Monthly Scorecard

43

PART SEVEN — PRACTICE

Real Office Scenarios

Sixteen situations, built from how Brandstro actually runs. Talk through each one with the Founder before it happens for real.

01 The Packaging Team misses another deadline

WEAK MOVE	Take over the project personally to "just get it done."
STRONG MOVE	Sit with the Packaging Team Leader, run the 5 Whys, find whether it's capacity, handoff, or skill — then fix that, not this one project.
ASK	Is this the first time, or the fifth?
OUTCOME	The Team Leader leaves the conversation with a plan, not a rescue.

02 A designer argues with their Team Leader in front of others

WEAK MOVE	Publicly side with one of them on the spot.
STRONG MOVE	Separate them, hear both privately, resolve the actual issue, coach the Team Leader on de-escalating next time.
ASK	What was actually being disagreed about — creative direction, or something else entirely?
OUTCOME	The disagreement gets resolved without anyone losing face publicly.

03 A Team Leader is technically excellent but poor at managing people

WEAK MOVE	Let it slide because their own design output is strong.
STRONG MOVE	Name it directly — leadership and craft are different skills — and coach the specific behaviour (e.g. never delegating, avoiding hard conversations).
ASK	Is their team's performance actually good, or just their own personal output?
OUTCOME	They start being evaluated as a leader, not just a designer.

04 One designer consistently outperforms the rest of the team

WEAK MOVE	Quietly route all the hardest work to them, burning them out.
STRONG MOVE	Recognise them, and ask what's different about their approach that others could learn.
ASK	Are they a future Team Leader, or a specialist who's happiest designing?
OUTCOME	Their strength lifts the team instead of just carrying it.

05 A talented designer has poor discipline — late, inconsistent, misses small details

WEAK MOVE	Excuse it because the work is good when it does show up.
STRONG MOVE	Hold the same standard as everyone else — talent doesn't buy an exemption.
ASK	Would I accept this from someone whose work was average?
OUTCOME	The team sees standards apply equally, which protects morale.

06 A designer keeps escalating small problems to you directly

WEAK MOVE	Solve it for them every time — it's faster.
STRONG MOVE	Redirect them to their Team Leader, and tell the Team Leader this is happening.
ASK	Is this a training gap, a confidence gap, or a sign the Team Leader is unapproachable?
OUTCOME	The right level starts handling the right problems again.

07 A client's revision requests suddenly spike mid-project

WEAK MOVE	Absorb it silently and let the designer's workload quietly balloon.
STRONG MOVE	Check whether this is a genuine miss on the brief or scope creep, and involve the CRM if it's the latter.
ASK	Was this covered in the original brief, or is it new ground?
OUTCOME	The team's time is protected, and the client relationship stays clear.

08 Thirty new clients land in a month the team can only fully serve six to eight of

WEAK MOVE	Tell everyone to just work faster and hope it evens out.
STRONG MOVE	Build a capacity plan, communicate realistic timelines to new clients, and flag the sales/delivery mismatch to the Founder with numbers.
ASK	Is this a one-off surge, or the new normal we need to resource for?
OUTCOME	Expectations are set honestly instead of quietly missed.

09 A team is sitting idle while another is buried

WEAK MOVE	Not notice until someone complains.
STRONG MOVE	Use the shared status view to redistribute work or cross-train where possible.
ASK	Is this a one-week blip, or a sign of an underlying allocation problem?
OUTCOME	Capacity gets used where it's actually needed.

10 A Team Leader hides a performance issue on their team

WEAK MOVE	Only address it once it becomes a client-facing problem.
STRONG MOVE	Address it directly and privately — this is about trust, not just the underlying issue.
ASK	Did they hide it out of fear, or because they didn't think it mattered?
OUTCOME	The Team Leader understands hiding problems costs more trust than surfacing them.

11 An employee complains about unfair workload distribution

WEAK MOVE	Dismiss it without checking the actual numbers.
STRONG MOVE	Check the workload dashboard before responding — the complaint might be right.
ASK	Is the imbalance real, or does it just feel that way from where they sit?
OUTCOME	The response is grounded in fact, not just reassurance.

12 A high performer starts acting arrogant toward teammates

WEAK MOVE	Ignore it because their output is too valuable to risk upsetting them.
STRONG MOVE	Address the behaviour directly — high output doesn't exempt anyone from team culture.
ASK	Is this affecting the rest of the team's morale or output?
OUTCOME	Standards hold regardless of who's involved.

13 A junior designer shows early leadership potential

WEAK MOVE	Wait until a Team Leader role is vacant to notice them.
STRONG MOVE	Start giving them small ownership now — a mini-project lead, mentoring someone newer.
ASK	What's the smallest piece of real responsibility I could hand them this month?
OUTCOME	The leadership pipeline (Section 22) actually fills.

14 The same design mistake keeps happening on packaging files

WEAK MOVE	Correct it each time it appears and move on.
STRONG MOVE	Treat it as a system gap — add it to the pre-presentation checklist (Section 28) so it's caught structurally.
ASK	Has this happened at least three times? If so, it's a system problem now, not an individual one.
OUTCOME	The mistake stops recurring across the whole team, not just for one person.

15 A deadline is tomorrow and the work is visibly incomplete

WEAK MOVE	Panic, jump in and do it yourself overnight.
STRONG MOVE	Assess honestly with the Team Leader what's achievable, communicate to the client early if it's genuinely at risk, and only then decide who does what.
ASK	Could this have been flagged three days ago instead of tonight?
OUTCOME	A managed, honest outcome instead of a scramble — and a lesson for next time.

16 The Founder receives a direct complaint about creative quality

WEAK MOVE	Get defensive or downplay it to protect the team's reputation.
STRONG MOVE	Investigate honestly, bring the Founder the cause and a fix — not just an explanation.
ASK	Is this an isolated miss, or does it match a pattern I should already know about?
OUTCOME	The Founder trusts you more after the conversation, not less.

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PART SEVEN — PRACTICE

Leadership Self-Reflection Questions

Ask yourself these on repeat. Nobody else will ask them for you.

DAILY

- Did I improve the team today, or just react to it?
- Did I help a Team Leader get better at solving their own problem?
- Did I create dependency on myself anywhere today?
- Did I communicate clearly, or did I assume it landed?

WEEKLY

- Which team improved this week — and which one declined?
- Which Team Leader needs support I haven't offered yet?
- What problem repeated from last week?
- Who deserves recognition I haven't given?
- What system needs improving before it breaks again?

MONTHLY

- Is the department stronger than it was last month — measurably, not just by feel?
- Are my Team Leaders becoming more independent, or more reliant on me?
- Is quality improving? Is productivity?
- Are problems reducing, or just changing shape?
- Is the team ready for the next stage of growth?

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PART SEVEN — PRACTICE

The Leader's Monthly Scorecard

Thirteen categories. Rate honestly, 1 to 5, with the Founder — this is a conversation, not a report card.

#	CATEGORY	1	2	3	4	5
1	Overall Team Performance					
2	Team Leader Development					
3	Productivity					
4	Quality					
5	Deadline Management					
6	Problem Solving					
7	Employee Development					
8	Communication					
9	Discipline & Culture					
10	Process Improvement					
11	Cross-Team Coordination					
12	Leadership Pipeline					
13	Strategic Thinking					

1 = needs urgent attention · 3 = meeting the bar · 5 = a model other leaders should learn from

Discussion Pages — End of Part Seven

FOUNDER'S NOTES

CREATIVE HEAD'S NOTES

KEY AGREEMENTS

ACTION ITEMS

ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	REVIEW DATE

FOUR SECTIONS

Partnership & Close

How you and the Founder work together, what success actually looks like, the principles to carry forward, and a commitment to sign.

46 Founder ↔ Creative Head Working Relationship

47 What Success Looks Like

48 Final Leadership Principles

49 My Leadership Commitment

46

PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

Founder ↔ Creative Head Working Relationship

Don't bring only problems to the Founder. Bring problems already halfway solved.

FOUNDER PROVIDES

- Direction and strategic priorities
- Feedback on your leadership
- Resources and major decisions
- Major escalation support

CREATIVE HEAD PROVIDES

- Honest department status
- Problems, with analysis attached
- Performance insights and trends
- Recommendations and escalations

THE FORMAT THAT EARNS TRUST

Problem + Analysis + Options + Recommendation. Not just "Packaging is behind again."

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PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

What Success Looks Like

The answer is not "you personally do excellent design work."

- Team Leaders become stronger, more independent decision-makers
- Teams become less dependent on you being in the room
- Performance, quality and deadlines all trend upward
- Repeated problems decrease, month over month
- Employees are visibly developing, with a named next skill each
- The Founder needs to intervene less in day-to-day creative operations
- Brandstro can handle greater workload without breaking
- Future leaders are already emerging from inside the teams

HOLD ONTO THIS

The best evidence of your leadership is the performance of the people you lead — not the quality of what you personally produce.

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PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

Final Leadership Principles

Twenty principles worth returning to whenever a situation feels unfamiliar.

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. Lead people, not tasks. | 1. Don't create dependency on yourself. |
| 2. Build leaders, not followers. | 2. Standards must be consistent for everyone. |
| 3. Fix systems, not just symptoms. | 3. Don't play favourites. |
| 4. Measure before judging. | 4. Every recurring problem needs a system. |
| 5. Coach before criticising. | 5. Every leader needs feedback, including you. |
| 6. Delegate before doing it yourself. | 6. Every employee needs a visible path to improve. |
| 7. Be firm without being disrespectful. | 7. Protect quality. |
| 8. Be approachable without becoming weak. | 8. Protect culture. |
| 9. Praise publicly; correct privately. | 9. Think beyond today's deadline. |
| 10. Never hide a problem. | 10. Leave the team stronger than you found it. |

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PART EIGHT – PARTNERSHIP & CLOSE

My Leadership Commitment

Read this aloud together at the end of the session.

MY COMMITMENT

I take ownership of the performance of every team I lead — Logo, Packaging, R&D and Content — not by doing their work, but by developing the people who do.

I will support my Team Leaders before I bypass them, coach before I criticise, and build systems before I accept the same problem twice.

I will maintain the standards this agency is built on, treat every person fairly, and bring problems to the Founder honestly — with analysis and a recommendation, not just a complaint.

I will build an environment where great creative work happens whether or not I am personally in the room. That is how I will measure whether I am succeeding.

Creative Head Name: _____ Signature: _____

Date: _____

Founder Name: _____ Signature: _____

Date: _____